

Count Down Under

Playtest record set | GAME 1501 A3, Pitch-Ready Prototype
Sprint cycle 28 July to 21 August 2026 | Group of four

Method

Player observation happened in two clusters: two sessions on 10 August 2026, the midpoint of the cycle, and a final round between 18 and 21 August. Notes were taken on paper at the time and are transcribed below without alteration beyond grouping. The revision attributed to each observation was reconstructed afterwards from the project's commit history, because the original notes were not filed alongside the code and no commit message references a playtest. Where a link could not be established with confidence it is marked as such rather than asserted.

The final round carries a caveat. Sessions 1 to 3 were observed directly by a member of the team. Round 4 is second-hand: team members recruited players and relayed what they found in the project Discord. Some of those messages mix the team member's own replay with what their recruited player reported, and do not consistently separate the two.

Session 1: Expert review

Date: 10 August 2026 **Observer:** a former instructor of the group **Format:** reviewed build, verbal notes taken by the team

Observation focus: production quality and rendering. This was a review by an experienced developer, not a first-time player session, and the record is treated as expert feedback rather than player behaviour.

Player-behaviour observations

- Did not know that the player had to jump through buildings.
- Dangers read as intentional.

Readability notes

- Reveal that the tunnels are where the player can go.
- Show a light for the tunnel.

Art and implementation notes

- Bat sprite reads well. Vampire spritesheet needs more frames.
- Reorder the player prefab construction for the spritesheet so no GetComponent call is required.

Rendering notes

- Post-processing: chromatic aberration plus colour correction.
- Lighting: 2D spot lights with volumetric effects.
- Bloom plus chromatic aberration.
- Move from a box volume to a dedicated volume with colour adjustments.

Session 2: Player observation

Date: 10 August 2026 **Player:** a relative of one team member, no prior exposure to the prototype **Observer:** that team member, taking notes during play

Observation focus: whether a first-time player could read the controls, the objective and the environment without instruction.

What the player understood

- Did not take long to work out the controls and their purposes.
- Understood the environment.
- Navigating over buildings and through the tunnels made sense.

What the player missed

- Did not get the sightseeing objective. The observer sketched a proposed HUD counter reading “sights to see 1/3” in the upper left of the screen, alongside two further screen mockups bracketed and labelled Animation / VFX.

Bugs and feel

- Dashing through lights.
- Movement continues sometimes.
- Got caught on the crocodile.
- Clock not working.
- Flight not always working.
- Analogue controls: delay in directional change.
- Flying is mechanically diverse but not yet tight. Could be tighter.

Difficulty and design

- Hard to die. May need to be more difficult.
- The alligator jump is confusing. The lunge attack may be on the wrong animal.
- Asked what they wished was in the game: the people should flee from Dracula.

Session 3: Outside players

Date: 18 August 2026, submission day **Players:** two members of college staff with no connection to the game programme, one from Foundations and one from administration **Observer:** a team member, taking notes during play

Observation focus: whether players outside the programme, with no idea what the prototype was meant to demonstrate, could read the controls and the objective. These were the first players in the cycle who were not a teammate, a teammate's relative, or an instructor.

Player A, Foundations

- First instinct was to attack with the mouse.
- Read Z as a generic “magic button”.
- Mixed up X and Z repeatedly.
- Enjoys vampire fiction and wanted to see more of it in the game.
- Liked the music.
- Wanted the game darker.
- Suggested a change to the streetlamp design.
- Noted that players tend to keep whatever the default settings are.

Observer's reference note: Star Stable Online, as a keyboard layout reference.

Player B, Administration

- Figured out the controls quickly.
- Died and immediately replayed.
- Asked why the controls were not on the main menu.
- Did not want to enter bat form every time.
- General traversal confusion.
- Did not understand the objectives.
- The humour in the game's description is not present in the game itself.
- Wanted more basic movement.

Observer's reference note: Dracula: Dead and Loving It, as a tone reference.

What this session confirms

- "Did not understand the objectives" independently repeats the finding from 10 August, from a player with no connection to the first session. The objective has now failed to communicate to two unrelated players eight days apart.
- Control legibility is a distinct problem from traversal: one player learned the scheme quickly and still could not read the level, while the other could not hold the X and Z mapping at all.
- Immediate replay after death is the strongest positive signal in the record set.

Round 4: Relayed player feedback

Dates: 18 to 21 August 2026 **Source:** players recruited by team members, reported back in the project Discord

Format: written summaries, second-hand

Observation focus: whether the build held up as a full run for players who had not seen it before. This round produced the sharpest notes in the project and arrived with three days left in the cycle.

Pacing and tension

- The sunrise timer is too slow. There is very little tension and it is sometimes possible to stand around.
- Bat form recharges quickly enough to fly more or less indefinitely; possibly just the aerial recharge rate.
- The dash is slow relative to how fast the player already moves. Either slow the player or make the dash faster with a shorter duration.

Combat and hazards

- The kangaroo's attack hitbox is too large and stays active too long.
- The ground check is too large.
- The crocodile feels good but could do more damage. Alternatively everything could do more damage, or the player could have less health, because healing is slow for how little difference it makes.
- The crocodile is sometimes very punishing and its animations are faster than others. Proposed principle: smaller damage means a faster enemy, bigger damage means a slower one, and bigger plus faster is reserved for a boss.

Level design and choice

- The level does not force enough choices. Parkour is fine but there is little branching.

- Wanted areas with a clear reward such as a victim behind greater danger, set against safer areas with less reward. Some of this exists; there is room for more.
- Static obstacles feel randomly placed and are not impactful beyond being hard to jump without taking a hit. They would carry more weight in more deliberate positions.
- Placing victims where obstacles will attack the player does not make much sense.
- There is room to make bat form necessary rather than optional; jumping onto ledges is currently one-note, and requiring a combination of both would be better.

Bugs and inconsistency

- Some buildings still do not appear to be on the ground layer.
- Audio is inconsistent: victims sometimes scream when drained and sometimes do not.
- Animation is inconsistent: the player sometimes floats through platforms, as though the ground check has not resolved.
- The player's bite is off model, possibly a reaction to how the victim models are positioned.
- Untextured placeholder squares are still visible on the sightseeing spots and on the airport ending trigger. The interaction should stay; the squares should not.
- The letterbox around the game still renders blue rather than black on any display that is not 16:9.

What held up

- Mechanically the game works. Being pinned by a crocodile and escaping with bat form was called out as working as intended.
- Jumping, bat form, biting, platforming, avoiding obstacles, the UI and the menus were all reported as feeling good.
- The art reads better with the less aggressive textures.
- Death makes sense, and the flashing damage HUD was singled out as effective.
- The environment looks solid.

Revisions driven by round 4

Observation	Revision	Date
Timer too slow, no tension, possible to stand around	Sunrise timer set to 180 seconds, then cut to 90	18, 20 Aug
Placeholder objective list still showing the old version of the sightseeing objective	TODO list turned off; unused text removed from the second end screen	20 Aug
Ground check too large; kangaroo attack too large and too long	Player hitbox tightened; attack and idle strategies modified	20 Aug
Menu art misaligning on non-16:9 windows	Web build resolution set to 1280x720; end screen scaling reset	18 Aug

Attempted and reverted: moving the jump attack onto the kangaroo. It left players stuck against obstacles with no escape even after the attack cooldown was increased, so the asymmetry between the two animals is unresolved at submission.

Revisions driven by the 10 August sessions

Every change committed to the project after 10 August traces to one of the two sessions held that day. Dates are commit dates.

Observation	Revision	Date
Vampire spritesheet needs more frames; flight not always working; the Animation / VFX mockups	Falling animation, eating animation, NPC idle and death replaced in the game scene, bat animation pass	12 Aug
Got caught on the crocodile; alligator jump confusing, lunge attack may be on the wrong animal	Crocodile and kangaroo art produced and animated	13 Aug
Analogue controls delay in directional change; flying could be tighter	Cinemachine camera with lookahead added; camera deadzone tuned	13, 18 Aug
Chromatic aberration, colour correction, 2D spot lights, volumetrics, dedicated volume	Lighting prefabs and post-processing pass, then a second post-processing pass	15, 16 Aug
Reveal the tunnels; show a light for the tunnel; did not know he had to jump through buildings	Level design update to the game scene; dawn fade added; audio trigger frequency increased	16, 17 Aug

Observations the sessions found already addressed and still failing

Two items had shipped before 10 August and the session showed the underlying problem was not solved. These are recorded separately because they are the most useful records in the set: in both cases the group believed the issue was closed.

Observation on 10 Aug	What already existed	Built
Player did not understand the sightseeing objective; observer sketched a redesign of the counter	A "Sights to See" counter was already in the build	6 Aug
Vampire spritesheet needs more frames	Additional frames had already been added to the vampire animations	4 Aug

The sightseeing objective remained incompletely implemented at submission.

Recorded and not acted on

Observation	Decision
The people should flee from Dracula	Declined for this cycle. Recorded as a candidate for further development rather than built, on scope grounds.
Hard to die, may need to be more difficult	No difficulty change was made after 10 August. Not consciously declined; it was not picked up.
Clock not working	Clock wiring was committed on 10 August, the same day as the sessions. The order of the two cannot be established from the project history.

Still open at submission

- Placeholder squares on the sightseeing spots and the airport ending trigger.
- Player bite alignment against victim models.
- Blue rather than black letterbox on non-16:9 displays.
- Balance between the crocodile and the kangaroo.
- Level design branching, and making bat form necessary rather than optional.
- Audio and animation inconsistency on drain and on landing.

Coverage note: one observation day in the first three weeks, on 10 August, with both observers drawn from the group's immediate circle. Every other player session in the project happened between 18 and 21 August, the final four days. That concentration, and what it cost, is addressed in the individual reflection.